

https://www.somdnews.com/independent/news/local/charles-board-of-education-delegation-discuss-legislative-priorities/article_ca4a0906-4b15-4da5-bc33-96153ee7b593.html

Charles board of education, delegation discuss legislative priorities

Ilana Williams iwilliams@somdnews.com
Nov 5, 2025



Members of the Charles board of education and Superintendent Maria Navarro present legislative priorities to Charles commissioners and state delegation during their annual legislative breakfast on Nov. 4.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

The Charles school board, county commissioners and state delegation convened Tuesday morning for breakfast to discuss legislative priorities for bills in the upcoming General Assembly session.

Two main priorities were on the agenda — improving information between juvenile services agencies and addressing funding challenges with the Blueprint for Maryland's Future.

The school system and other county agencies can respond to incidents that occur in the community and support a student, Superintendent Maria Navarro said. But it becomes challenging when students move from one county to another.

Local officials have worked on systemwide emergency preparedness and safety in schools that include emergency staff, the sheriff's office, students and county government and school staff, Navarro said.

Another way to address the issue is through the Commission on Juvenile Justice Reform & Emerging & Best Practices that was created by House Bill 814 in 2024, Navarro said. Members meet monthly to work on providing coordination services and communications for treatment programs of juveniles.

“It is important for us to know so we can properly prepare the right education setting for young people while they're getting services,” she said.

A new bill has not been drafted, but jurisdictions plan to bring forward ideas about this type of coordination and communication during the upcoming session that starts in January, Navarro said.

Language in the bill could include information regarding juveniles who transfer between local school systems and expanding information shared by law enforcement to superintendents or school systems within 24 hours of any arrest of a student. Also, enhancements to the “reportable offenses” law should include tools for communication between education systems and a central repository through the Maryland State Department of Education or similar entity.

“This is always tough,” Del. Debra M. Davis (D) said. “We’re always critical of these bills and how they affect our community disparity.”

It’s important to have this communication, but also allowing the school system to offer support services, Commissioner Amanda Stewart (D) said. There needs to be a responsibility not to just protect the child, but “to protect the entire school community.”

Another priority was funding challenges of the Blueprint of Maryland’s Future, the state’s education reform plan.

Maryland has seen a decline in student enrollment, Christina Miller, coordinator of District Innovation for Charles public schools, said. Because of this, there are concerns about implementing programs associated with the Blueprint, some of which offer funding per pupil.

The first concern is less funding from the state and the county, Miller said. The school district is asking for a rolling average of all funding sources to continue the programs.

The other funding challenge is how the school system identifies students to offer compensatory education, a way the district can provide additional services for students, Miller said. Previously, the district could identify students using direct services and applications for things like Medicaid and Free and Reduced Meals. Now, the district has to choose.

“We’re leaving out students that need additional funding,” Miller said. “This is something that we hope can be changed in the law.”

Another concern brought up is principals and assistant principals will need to meet National Board Certification requirements to work in Maryland, Miller said. The school district asked delegates to not have this requirement, which is rigorous and

beyond normal certification.

A principal in Charles County, who is certified, is not getting funding because it's not considered "student-facing," Sean Heyl, president of the Education Association of Charles County, said.

The board of education is also supporting a bill to increase the student board member scholarship from \$1,000 to \$5,000 to start next July, Eric Schwartz, staff attorney for Charles public schools, said. This proposal was included in the Charles commissioners' packet for the delegation to consider.

The compensation has not increased over the past 10 years, Schwartz said. The chair of the board of education receives \$7,000 a year and other board members receive \$6,000.

"The \$5,000 scholarship is more reflective of what that commitment is today," he said.

Del. Edith J. Patterson (D) recommended an addendum to include an increase in compensation for elected school board members as well.

"One thing ... is to make sure that Charles County has the best opportunities for our students as well as the teachers and for support for boards," she said.



Breakfast meeting

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News Nov 4, 2025